discipline was ensured, and rules were taught with an iron hand. There was no room for even the slightest error, during training as well as in battle.

After only a day, the tiredness reflected on our drooping faces. I could feel every muscle in my body turning sore. The skin on my back burnt as sweat rolled down the cuts and bruises from having continuously rolled on gravel. As I took a shower in the evening, right before the open-door study period, I convinced myself to shut my mind and stop worrying—it was the only way I would make it through the academy. Open-door study period was observed for an hour every evening, from seven to eight. The juniors would sit and study, and one senior would be on watch. If anybody was found sleeping, the entire batch of first-termers would get punished after dinner. And after a day's backbreaking training, sleep was unavoidable. So were the late-night punishments. Somehow, I made it through the study period and went for dinner with Anuradha. Each first-termer was made to sit next to a senior-term flight cadet, and it was the senior's responsibility to teach mess etiquette to the first-termer. The teaching inside the mess would go on for only a week. Punishments would follow later, if mistakes still persisted. A-first term cadet would generally be so lost trying to catch up with the tight schedule that mistakes would be unavoidable. It is rightly said that punishments lay eggs. One punishment always leads to another and so on.

Dinner inside the FCM was well-cooked, balanced and delicious. It was followed by mouth-watering pudding. Tired as we were, we were all famished and ate like horses. Luckily, we were allowed to sleep at nine, which was the official 'lights-off' time. While I was preparing my dress for the next day, I started to miss home. To avoid homesickness, I thought of going to Anuradha's cabin next to mine. She wasn't asleep either. When I entered her cabin, she was struggling to put her towel on the window to cover it. Curtains were not yet issued to the cadets due to some logistical delay and we had had to think of makeshift arrangements.

'They expect us to undergo ragda but can't even provide curtains on time,' I commented as I helped Anuradha.

'Must have been an administrative officer's laziness,' she said.